

sign a summons to appear in court for a delinquent bill. She panicked and started a crying spell that lasted a whole day. Fortunately, Jack was shaken enough that he sought immediate counsel from his pastor who sent them to a volunteer financial counselor.

The bottom line was they owed: (1) \$7,000 in credit card bills that required a minimum payment of nearly \$250 a month, (2) a car lease of \$180 a month, (3) school loans of \$70 a month, and (4) a promise of \$100 to repay a loan to a family member. Just the minimum payments on the debts alone took nearly 30 percent of their total income.

Fortunately for this couple, they were offered the chance to move in with Penny's parents. With a newfound humility, Jack discovered the truth found in Proverbs 15:16. "Better is a little with the fear of the Lord, than great treasure and turmoil with it." It took nearly all of the surplus income for three years to get the consumer debt paid. It will take them another five years to get rid of Jack's school loans. Jack found it would not be possible for him to go to seminary and pay on his loans. He elected to attend a correspondence seminary while still working.

AVOID THE EXTREMES

There are two extremes that many couples often adopt in their finances. One is to be too lax and not do any financial planning at all. That's typical of most young couples today. In fact, I would venture to say that most young couples don't know within \$100 a month what it costs them to live and don't know within \$50 how much is in their checking accounts. When asked, "How do you think you're going to get by?" they often reply, "Well, we'll just have to trust God."

They think they're operating on faith. In fact, they are operating on presumption, or what I call the "bird-in-the-field" syndrome. Consider Christ's parable recorded in Matthew 6:26: "Look at the birds of the air, that they do not sow, neither do they reap, nor gather into barns, and yet your Heavenly Father feeds them. Are you not worth much more than they?" If